

Course AI Policy Builder Guide

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Audience: Faculty, instructional staff, academic leadership, and curriculum support staff

Related documents: Standard_Student_AI_Use_Policy.md, Faculty_Admin_AI_Use_Guide_Draft.md

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Purpose

This guide helps faculty create course-specific AI use policies and assignment-level AI expectations.

The college may have a general student AI use standard, but students need course-specific guidance. A general rule rarely answers the practical question students actually have:

Can I use AI on this course, this assignment, in this way?

This guide gives faculty a repeatable process for turning the standard student AI use policy into a clear course artifact for a specific course number, course name, instructional context, and assignment structure.

What This Guide Produces

Faculty may use this guide to create:

- a syllabus AI use statement
- a course AI use addendum
- an assignment-level AI use policy
- a Blackboard, Canvas, or LMS policy page
- a student-facing AI disclosure requirement
- a course-specific explanation of manual-first, restricted, or integrated AI use

The output should be student-facing, plain-language, and specific enough that students can follow it without guessing.

Core Design Principle

AI policy should protect learning, not merely police tools.

The strongest course AI policies explain:

- what students are allowed to do
- what students are not allowed to do
- when AI use changes from support into substitution
- what students must disclose
- what students must still understand and explain
- why the course handles AI the way it does

The central question is not simply:

- “Did the student use AI?”

The stronger course-level question is:

- “Did the student use AI in a way that still supports the learning goals of this course?”

Inputs Faculty Should Gather

Before drafting a course AI policy, gather the following:

- Course number
- Course name
- Course modality
- Course level
- Major course outcomes
- Major assignment types
- Whether AI literacy is part of the course
- Whether students are beginners, intermediate learners, or advanced learners
- Which activities must measure unaided skill
- Which activities may allow AI support
- Which activities may require or encourage AI use
- Whether students must disclose AI use
- Whether disclosure should be brief or detailed
- Which tools are approved or expected
- Which data students must not enter into AI tools
- How AI misuse will be handled

Course AI Use Levels

Faculty should identify the expected AI use level for the course overall and, when needed, for individual assignments.

Level 0 - No AI Use

AI use is not allowed for this activity.

Use this level when the activity is intended to measure unaided performance, independent recall, foundational fluency, or individual problem-solving without outside assistance.

Possible examples:

- quizzes
- exams
- in-class skill checks
- initial drafts intended to show unaided ability
- basic syntax or vocabulary practice
- practical demonstrations of core skills

Student-facing language:

AI tools may not be used for this activity. This task is designed to measure what you can do independently at this point in the course.

Level 1 - Manual First, AI After Attempt

Students must attempt the work independently first. AI may then be used for clarification, feedback, revision, debugging, or reflection.

Use this level when students are still developing foundational skills, but AI can support learning after meaningful human effort.

Possible examples:

- early programming assignments
- writing drafts
- problem-solving worksheets
- design sketches

- study explanations
- debugging after the student has attempted diagnosis

Student-facing language:

You must make a serious attempt before using AI. After that attempt, you may use AI for clarification, revision, debugging, or feedback. You must still understand and explain your final work.

Level 2 - AI as Support

Students may use AI throughout the work process as a support tool, but they remain responsible for decisions, accuracy, quality, and explanation.

Use this level when AI can reasonably support the assignment without replacing the intended learning.

Possible examples:

- brainstorming
- outlining
- editing
- comparing approaches
- improving wording
- generating examples
- reviewing code
- refining project plans

Student-facing language:

AI may be used as a support tool for this activity. You may use it to brainstorm, revise, clarify, or improve your work, but you remain responsible for the final result and must be able to explain your choices.

Level 3 - AI as Integrated Workflow

Students are expected or encouraged to use AI as part of the assignment process, while documenting how they used it and how they evaluated the results.

Use this level when responsible AI use is part of the learning goal, professional simulation, technical workflow, or advanced project design.

Possible examples:

- AI literacy assignments
- advanced project work
- workplace simulation
- prompt engineering activities
- AI-assisted coding workflows
- critique and validation exercises
- comparing human and AI-generated approaches

Student-facing language:

AI use is part of this activity. You are expected to document how you used AI, what it produced, what you accepted or rejected, and how you verified the final result.

Decision Framework

Use the following questions to choose the right AI level.

1. What is the assignment actually measuring?

If the assignment measures independent recall, unaided skill, or foundational fluency, consider Level 0 or Level 1.

If the assignment measures judgment, synthesis, revision, project execution, or professional process, consider Level 2 or Level 3.

2. Would AI use bypass the learning goal?

If AI can complete the central learning task for the student, restrict it or require manual-first work.

If AI can support the student without replacing the learning task, allow bounded use.

3. Can the student still explain the final result?

If explanation is essential, require students to document their reasoning, decisions, testing, sources, or revision process.

4. Is disclosure needed?

Disclosure is useful when AI significantly shapes the final product, when students use AI to generate content, when the course is teaching responsible AI use, or when instructors need visibility into process.

5. Are there data or privacy concerns?

Students should not enter private, protected, confidential, or personally identifiable information into AI tools. Courses should use public, fictional, anonymized, or synthetic examples whenever possible.

6. Does the policy match the course level?

Introductory courses may need more manual-first work. Advanced courses may appropriately integrate AI into professional workflows.

Recommended Course Policy Structure

A course-specific AI policy should include:

1. Course identification
2. Course-level AI position
3. Allowed uses
4. Prohibited uses
5. Manual-first expectations
6. Disclosure expectations
7. Assignment-specific variation
8. Data privacy warning
9. Student accountability statement
10. Consequences or academic integrity connection
11. Where students should ask questions

Course AI Policy Template

Faculty may copy and adapt the following template.

AI Use Policy for [Course Number: Course Name]

Course Position on AI

AI tools [are allowed / are allowed only when specified / are restricted / are integrated into selected course activities] in this course.

The purpose of this policy is to make clear when AI may support your learning and when it would interfere with the goals of the course.

Core Expectation

AI may assist your work, but it may not replace your responsibility for understanding, testing, revising, explaining, and submitting work that reflects your own learning.

If you use AI, you are responsible for:

- checking whether AI is allowed for the assignment
- understanding what AI produced
- verifying whether the output is correct
- revising or rejecting weak output
- explaining your final work
- disclosing AI use when required

Allowed AI Use

In this course, AI may be used for:

- [Allowed use 1]
- [Allowed use 2]
- [Allowed use 3]

Examples:

- brainstorming possible approaches
- clarifying unfamiliar concepts
- generating study questions
- improving wording or organization
- debugging after you have attempted the problem yourself
- comparing alternate solutions

Prohibited AI Use

In this course, AI may not be used for:

- [Prohibited use 1]
- [Prohibited use 2]
- [Prohibited use 3]

Examples:

- submitting AI-generated work you cannot explain
- using AI on AI-free quizzes, exams, or skill checks
- copying AI output without review or revision
- using AI to bypass required independent work
- hiding AI use when disclosure is required
- entering private, protected, or confidential information into AI tools

Manual-First Activities

Some activities in this course are manual-first.

For manual-first work, you must make a serious independent attempt before using AI. After that attempt, AI may be used only for the types of support allowed in the assignment instructions.

Manual-first activities in this course include:

- [Activity or assignment type]
- [Activity or assignment type]
- [Activity or assignment type]

Disclosure Requirement

For this course, AI disclosure is:

- [Not required for minor grammar or formatting support]
- [Required when AI contributes ideas, structure, code, analysis, images, citations, or substantial wording]
- [Required for all AI use]

When disclosure is required, include:

- what tool you used
- what you asked it to do
- what it produced
- what you accepted, changed, or rejected
- how you checked the final result

Assignment-Specific Rules

Assignment instructions may allow, restrict, or prohibit AI use differently from the general course policy.

When assignment instructions are more specific than this policy, follow the assignment instructions.

If you are unsure whether AI is allowed, ask before using it.

Data Privacy

Do not enter private, protected, confidential, or personally identifiable information into AI tools.

This includes information about yourself, classmates, instructors, employers, clients, patients, or other real people unless the assignment explicitly provides approved instructions for doing so.

Use fictional, public, anonymized, or synthetic information when working with AI.

Final Accountability

The final work you submit must be work you understand and can explain.

If you cannot explain, defend, test, or revise the final result, you have not yet met the expectations of the assignment, even if AI helped produce it.

Academic Integrity

Using AI in ways that violate this policy, assignment instructions, or college academic integrity expectations may result in academic consequences.

The goal is not to punish responsible AI use. The goal is to protect learning, honesty, and fair evaluation.

Assignment-Level AI Rule Template

Course-level policy is helpful, but assignment-level rules are often clearer for students.

Faculty may add this block to individual assignments.

AI Use for This Assignment

AI use level: [Level 0 / Level 1 / Level 2 / Level 3]

For this assignment, AI is:

- [not allowed]
- [allowed only after your own attempt]
- [allowed as a support tool]
- [required or encouraged as part of the workflow]

You may use AI for:

- [Allowed use]
- [Allowed use]
- [Allowed use]

You may not use AI for:

- [Restricted use]
- [Restricted use]
- [Restricted use]

Disclosure:

- [No disclosure required]
- [Brief disclosure required]
- [Detailed AI use statement required]

You must be able to explain:

- your process
- your decisions
- your final answer, code, design, analysis, or product
- how you checked the quality or correctness of the work

Disclosure Templates for Students

Brief Disclosure

I used [AI tool] to [purpose]. I reviewed and revised the final work myself.

Example:

I used Microsoft Copilot to suggest clearer wording for two paragraphs. I reviewed and revised the final work myself.

Process Disclosure

I used [AI tool] to help with [purpose]. It produced [summary of output]. I accepted [what was used], changed [what was revised], and rejected [what was not used]. I verified the final work by [method].

Example:

I used AI to compare two possible project structures. It produced a list of advantages and disadvantages. I accepted the suggestion to separate the project into three sections, changed the wording to match the course vocabulary, and rejected one idea that did not meet the assignment requirements. I verified the final work against the rubric.

Technical Disclosure

I used [AI tool] to help with [debugging / refactoring / explanation / testing]. I had already attempted [what the student tried first]. I used the AI output to [specific use]. I tested the final result by [testing method].

Example:

I used AI to help debug a loop after I had already checked the variable names and console output. AI suggested that my loop condition was wrong. I changed the condition, tested three inputs, and confirmed that the final result matched the assignment requirements.

Faculty Drafting Prompt

Faculty may use the following prompt with an approved AI tool to generate a first draft.

You are helping me draft a student-facing AI use policy for a specific college course.

Use the following principles:

- AI may assist student work, but it may not replace student responsibility.
- Students remain responsible for understanding, checking, revising, explaining, and submitting their final work.
- Course-specific assignment instructions may be more restrictive than the general course policy.
- Manual-first work is allowed when the learning goal requires independent effort before AI support.
- AI use expectations should be clear enough that students can follow them without guessing.
- Students must not enter private, protected, confidential, or personally identifiable information into AI tools.

Course information:

- Course number:
- Course name:
- Course level:
- Modality:
- Major course outcomes:
- Major assignment types:
- Student experience level:
- Is AI literacy a course outcome?
- Overall AI use level: [Level 0 / Level 1 / Level 2 / Level 3 / mixed by assignment]
- Activities where AI is not allowed:
- Activities that are manual-first:
- Activities where AI is allowed as support:
- Activities where AI is integrated or encouraged:
- Disclosure requirement:
- Approved or recommended tools:
- Specific concerns for this course:

Draft a clear student-facing course AI use policy with these sections:

1. Course Position on AI
2. Core Expectation
3. Allowed AI Use

4. Prohibited AI Use
5. Manual-First Activities
6. Disclosure Requirement
7. Assignment-Specific Rules
8. Data Privacy
9. Final Accountability
10. Academic Integrity

Use plain language. Keep the tone firm, fair, and supportive. Do not make the policy sound like AI is automatically cheating. Emphasize responsible use, student understanding, and human accountability.

Faculty Review Checklist

Before publishing a course AI policy, check:

- Does it align with the college's AI acceptable use policy?
- Does it align with the standard student AI use policy?
- Does it name what students may do?
- Does it name what students may not do?
- Does it clarify whether assignment rules can override the course rule?
- Does it identify manual-first or AI-free activities?
- Does it state whether disclosure is required?
- Does it explain what disclosure should include?
- Does it protect private, protected, confidential, and personally identifiable information?
- Does it preserve instructor authority over grading and feedback?
- Does it preserve student responsibility for understanding and explaining the final work?
- Could a student follow the policy without asking for clarification?
- Is the tone supportive rather than purely punitive?

Common Problems to Avoid

Too Vague

Weak:

Use AI responsibly.

Stronger:

You may use AI to brainstorm and revise your draft, but you may not submit AI-generated text without reviewing, revising, and disclosing how you used it.

Too Absolute

Weak:

AI is cheating.

Stronger:

AI use is not allowed on quizzes, exams, or manual-first skill checks. AI may be allowed on selected assignments when the instructions say so.

Too Tool-Specific

Weak:

ChatGPT is banned.

Stronger:

Only approved AI tools may be used, and only in the ways allowed by the assignment instructions.

Too Focused on Detection

Weak:

All AI use will be detected and punished.

Stronger:

You are expected to be honest about AI use when disclosure is required. The course will evaluate your understanding, process, and ability to explain your final work.

Example Course-Level Summary Statements

Introductory or Foundational Course

This course uses a manual-first approach. You will often be expected to try skills independently before using AI. AI may be used for clarification, study support, revision, or debugging when the assignment allows it, but you must be able to explain your final work.

Writing or Communication Course

AI may be used to brainstorm, organize ideas, revise wording, or receive feedback when permitted by the assignment. Your submitted work must reflect your own thinking, voice, revision choices, and understanding. Disclosure is required when AI contributes ideas, structure, or substantial wording.

Technical or Programming Course

AI may be used for explanation, debugging, comparison of approaches, and selected coding support when permitted. Some assignments are manual-first or AI-free to build foundational skill. You must understand, test, and explain any code you submit.

Advanced or Project-Based Course

AI may be used as part of the project workflow when documented and evaluated. You are responsible for deciding what to accept, change, or reject, and for verifying that the final product meets course requirements, technical standards, and ethical expectations.

Final Faculty Standard

A strong course AI policy should help students know what responsible AI use looks like before a problem occurs.

The goal is not to create fear around AI.

The goal is to protect learning, preserve trust, support fair evaluation, and make human accountability visible.